



SAMPLING PERCUSSION MOBILE

SPM-12

USER MANUAL



SP-1200 disk playback, editing, sampling and SP-12 transfer

Test edition · October 2026

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1. Introduction

SPM-12 opens, plays and edits E-mu SP-1200 floppy-disk images and compatible project files on macOS, iOS and Android. It recreates the disk's sounds, segments, songs, tuning, levels, output assignments, swing, tempo changes and saved mixes. It can also receive backups from an E-mu SP-12 over MIDI and send edited backups to the hardware.

The application is intended for musicians who want to audition old disks, arrange material away from the sampler, archive SP-12 memory, or export tracks through a software recreation of the SP-1200 signal path.

This test manual describes the current application in version 1.0.10. Screenshots were captured from the macOS build with the `JAZZRIM.hfe` disk loaded. Controls are arranged responsively, so phones and tablets may place the same controls slightly differently.

1.1 What SPM-12 opens

Format	Purpose
<code>.hfe</code>	SP-1200 floppy-disk image. Opens sounds, segments, songs and disk settings.
<code>.spm12</code>	SPM-12 project. Keeps the project in the application's editable format.
<code>.sp12</code>	Combined SP-12 sound-bank and sequence backup used by SPM-12.
<code>.SPLB12</code> + <code>.SPLQ12</code>	Legacy SPL-12 bank and sequence files. Select the pair together when opening.

The original source remains the safest archive. Use **Save** to write the current document format, or save a separate project when you want to preserve the source file.

Back up irreplaceable disks. Work from a copy until you have confirmed that the result opens and plays as expected.

1.2 Audio model

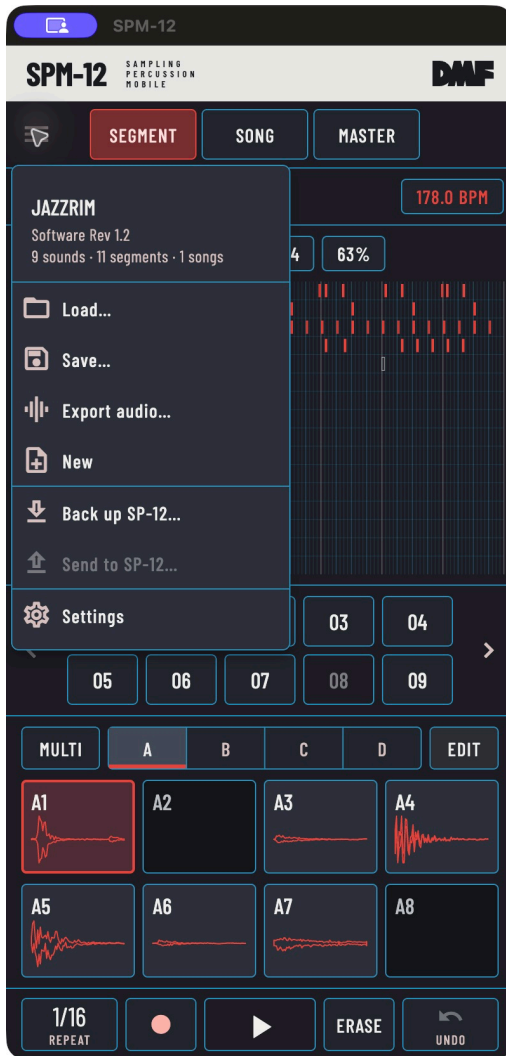
Playback runs at the SP-1200's internal 26.04 kHz clock. The eight outputs retain their characteristic filtering: outputs 1-2 use a swept low-pass response, outputs 3-4 and 5-6 use fixed low-pass responses, and outputs 7-8 are unfiltered. The Master view adds a modern mixer and effects stage after those outputs; see Master mixer and effects.

SP-12 user samples are preserved without converting their original rate. They therefore play approximately five percent lower and slower through the SP-1200 playback engine. Factory SP-12 ROM sounds are supplied by the application and are never written into an SP-12 backup.

2. Quick Start

2.1 Load a disk or project

1. Press the menu button at the upper left.
2. Choose **Load...**
3. Open a bookmarked folder or press **Open File** to use the system file picker.
4. Select an HFE disk, SPM-12 project or SP-12 backup.
5. Wait for the project name and contents summary to appear in the menu.



The project menu with JAZZRIM loaded. The summary reports nine sounds, eleven segments and one song.

The menu identifies the loaded project, the disk software revision, and the number of sounds, segments and songs. It also provides the document commands described in Files and projects.

2.2 Audition the project

1. Open the **SEGMENT** view.
2. Choose a populated segment from the numbered strip.
3. Press a populated pad to audition its sound.
4. Press **Play** in the transport to hear the segment.
5. Select banks **A-D** to reach all 32 pads.

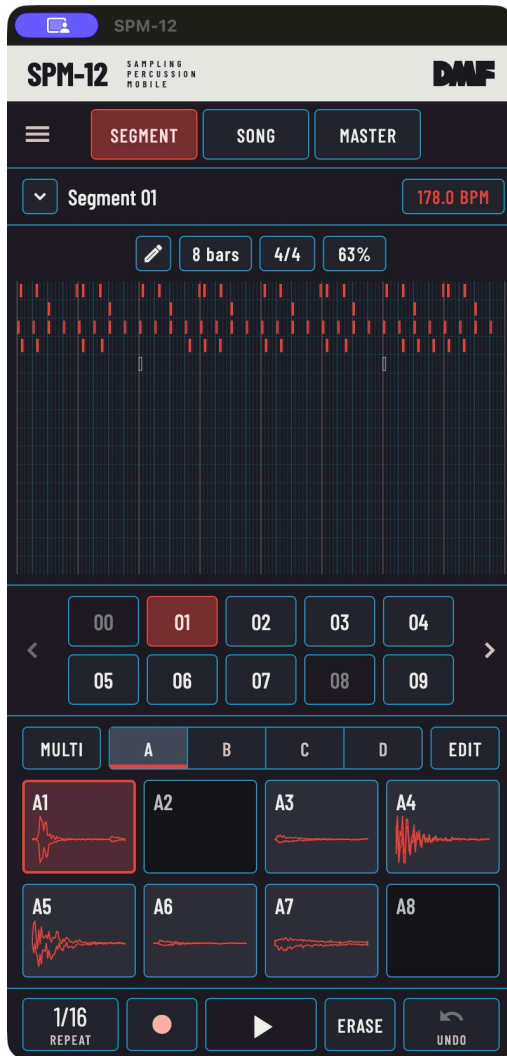
The selected pad is outlined. Pad flashes show sounds triggered by touch or by the sequencer. If a pad contains audio, its miniature waveform appears on the pad.

2.3 Save your work

Open the project menu and choose **Save....** Select a different filename if you want to retain the original. Saving an unchanged HFE disk preserves its contents byte for byte; edited sequence and song data may be laid out again when necessary.

3. Main Screen

The application has three main work areas: **SEGMENT**, **SONG** and **MASTER**. The pad area and transport remain available while moving between the musical views.



Segment 01 from the JAZZRIM disk.

3.1 Navigation and project menu

The top-left menu contains document and application actions. The three large navigation keys switch work areas without stopping playback. A highlighted key shows the active view.

3.2 Segment and song selectors

The numbered strip displays ten segments at a time. Use the arrows beside the strip to move between groups of ten. Number **00** represents an empty selection; populated numbers use the active theme's brighter text.

In Song view, the title at the top selects the current song. In Segment view, it selects the current segment. The tempo control is displayed at the right of the header.

3.3 Pads and banks

Banks **A**, **B**, **C** and **D** each contain eight pads. Press a pad to play its sound and select it for editing. Empty pads retain their position but do not produce audio.

Press **MULTI** to spread the selected pad across a 4-by-4 performance grid. Choose **PITCH** (or **DECAY**, depending on the sound mode) or **VOLUME**. Moving between grid areas retriggers the sound at the displayed step. Multiple touches can play independently on a touch screen.

Press **EDIT** to open the selected pad's sound editor. See Editing sounds.

3.4 Transport

The lower transport provides:

- **Repeat**: opens quantization, timing offset and Hold Repeat settings.
- **Record**: arms or enters pattern recording according to the active segment state.
- **Play**: starts, pauses or resumes playback.
- **Erase**: removes events while used with the relevant pads or editor.
- **Undo**: reverses the most recent supported edit.

Repeat quantization controls the musical division used for repeated pad triggers. Offset moves repeats around the grid, while **HOLD REPEAT** keeps the repeat active without continuously holding the control.

4. Segment View

A segment is the SP-1200's pattern unit. It contains timed pad events and musical settings, but it does not store a permanent playback tempo. When a song plays, the song supplies the tempo; outside a song, the current tempo control is used.

The Segment header shows:

- selected segment number;
- current tempo;
- segment length in bars;
- time signature;
- swing amount;
- a button for the full sequence editor.

4.1 Playing and selecting segments

Select a populated segment number and press **Play**. Selecting another segment changes the active pattern. Segment **00** is empty and is useful as a neutral selection.

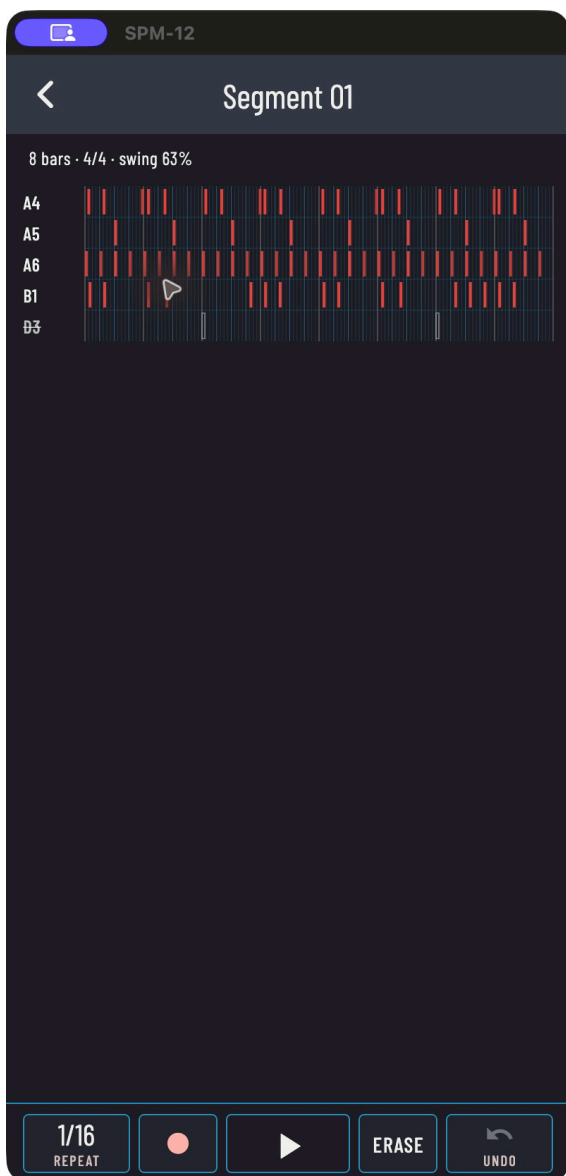
4.2 Length, time signature and swing

Press the bar-count, time-signature or swing control to edit it. The sequencer uses 24 ticks per quarter note. Swing delays every second eighth-note position to produce the characteristic uneven pulse.

Changing the structure of a segment can affect events near its end. Save a copy before making extensive structural edits.

4.3 Full sequence editor

Press the grid/editor button in the Segment header to open the full sequence editor.



The full sequence editor for Segment 01. Rows correspond to pads and columns show musical time.

The editor shows only pad rows that contain events. Use it to inspect the complete pattern and understand how hits align across the segment. The header repeats the segment's length, time signature and swing. The transport remains available at the bottom.

Use the back button at the upper left to return to the main Segment view.

5. Sounds and Sampling

5.1 Editing sounds

Select a populated pad and press **EDIT**.



The sound editor for pad A1.

The waveform displays the recorded sound and its active region. Drag the start and end markers to truncate playback. When a loop is present, its boundary is displayed in the waveform editor and can be adjusted.

The lower controls set:

- **Output:** routes the sound to SP-1200 output 1-8.
- **Pitch/Decay mode:** selects which hardware-style parameter is active.
- **Pitch or decay:** adjusts the active parameter.
- **Level:** sets the sound's attenuation level.

Changes are heard immediately and are written when the document is saved.

5.2 Recording and resampling

Open an empty pad with **EDIT** to enter the sampler. On a populated pad, open the sound editor and choose **Resample**.

1. Select an audio input device.
2. Check the input meter and avoid clipping.
3. Press **REC**.
4. Perform or play the source audio.
5. Press **STOP**, or allow recording to reach its maximum duration.
6. Trim and assign the new sound using the controls in Editing sounds.

Resampling replaces the selected pad after recording succeeds. Use **Cancel** to keep an existing sound when leaving the resampling panel.

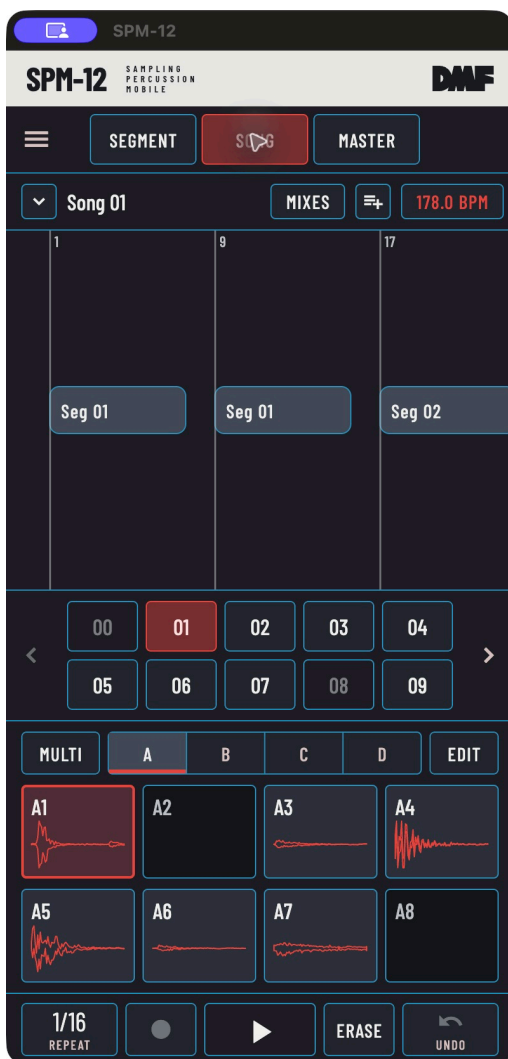
Input permission. The operating system may ask for microphone or audio-input access the first time sampling is opened.

5.3 ROM sounds in SP-12 backups

SP-12 factory pads play from the factory ROM bundled with SPM-12. They can be tuned, trimmed and looped, and their parameter changes can be saved. The ROM audio itself is not copied into `.sp12` files.

6. Song View

A song arranges segments and control steps into a larger performance.



Song 01 from JAZZRIM, showing segment steps and the shared performance pads.

The song header selects the current song, opens saved mixes, reveals special steps and sets the song tempo. The central timeline lists song steps in playback order.

6.1 Segment steps

Drag a segment from the numbered strip into the song timeline to add it. Reorder supported steps by dragging them to a new location. A segment step plays that segment once before advancing.

6.2 Special steps

Use the special-step button to show the palette. The current application supports:

- **Repeat start and repeat end:** repeat a group of steps for a fixed number of passes or indefinitely.
- **Tempo:** change tempo immediately or ramp over a number of beats.
- **Mix:** recall one of the eight saved mixes.
- **Sub-song:** call another song and return when it ends.
- **Trigger:** retain SP-1200 trigger-output settings in the arrangement.
- **End:** terminate playback.

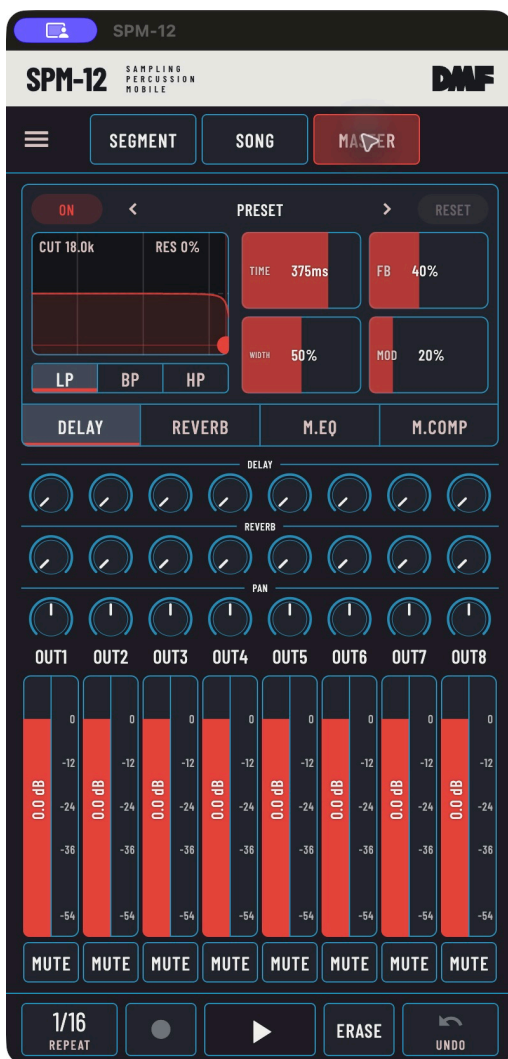
Missing segment references are skipped, matching the hardware behavior.

6.3 Song tempo

The song header holds the starting tempo, including tenths of a BPM. Tempo steps can change it later in the arrangement. When a disk is first opened, SPM-12 uses the first song tempo as the initial playback tempo when one is available.

7. Master Mixer and Effects

The Master view mixes the eight SP-1200 outputs and adds software effects after the hardware-style output filters.



The Master view with filter, delay and eight output channels.

7.1 Output channels

Each channel corresponds to one of the SP-1200's eight outputs. Every strip provides output level, mute, pan, delay send and reverb send. A sound reaches a strip according to the output assignment in its sound editor.

7.2 Master effects

Use the effect tabs to select **Delay**, **Reverb**, **Master EQ** or **Master Compressor**. The upper panel displays the selected effect parameters. The global **ON** control bypasses or enables the master processing, while **RESET** restores the current effect to its default values.

The filter pad controls cutoff and resonance. **LP**, **BP** and **HP** select low-pass, band-pass and high-pass behavior. Delay provides time, stereo width, feedback and modulation controls.

7.3 Presets

Use the preset controls to move through the available master-effect settings. Treat presets as starting points, then adjust parameters and sends to suit the project.

8. Files and Projects

8.1 New

New opens a clean project called `UNTITLED`. It contains the SP-1200 operating-system tracks and factory saved mixes, but no user sounds, segments or songs.

8.2 Load

Load... opens the document browser. Add frequently used folders as bookmarks, or use **Open File** to enter the system picker. On supported systems, opening a recognized file from Finder or Files also routes it to SPM-12.

For legacy SPL-12 backups, select the `.SPLB12` bank and `.SPLQ12` sequence file together. The application combines them into one editable SP-12 document.

8.3 Save

Save... writes the loaded document with its current edits. An HFE file is patched rather than regenerated: unchanged disk structures are preserved, and changed records receive updated data and checksums.

SP-12 documents save as `.sp12`. A complete backup contains both sequence and bank data. Saving an unedited backup preserves its wire payload.

Unreadable disk tracks. A track side that could not be read cannot safely be rewritten if an edit would change its data. SPM-12 reports the failure instead of silently producing a damaged disk.

8.4 Export audio

Export audio... renders a selected song or segment. Choose:

- the song or segment number;
- the number of passes, up to 16;
- **Output stems** for one mono file per active output 1-8;
- **Stereo mix** for the result through the mixer and master effects;
- **Tail** to continue until sounds and effects have rung out.

At least one of stems or stereo mix must be enabled.

9. SP-12 Backup and Restore

SPM-12 communicates with the SP-12 over bidirectional MIDI System Exclusive messages. Connect MIDI OUT from each device to MIDI IN on the other device. Prefer a wired, SysEx-capable interface.

Hardware validation. SP-12 transfer support has been verified against captured backup files and protocol data, but the current implementation still requires broader testing with physical SP-12 hardware.

9.1 Back up an SP-12

1. Open the project menu and choose **Back up SP-12....**
2. Select the MIDI input and output ports.
3. Follow the wizard to receive sequences first using the SP-12 Cassette operation shown on screen.
4. Continue to receive the sound bank.
5. Name and save the combined `.sp12` file.

The wizard reports transfer state and byte progress. A malformed or incomplete transfer is rejected rather than saved as a valid backup.

9.2 Send a backup to the SP-12

Open an `.sp12` document, then choose **Send to SP-12....** The command is disabled for other document types.

The wizard sends the sound bank first and the sequences second so sequence pad references land on the correct sounds. Follow the Cassette menu instructions presented for each phase and do not disconnect MIDI until completion is reported.

9.3 Transfer troubleshooting

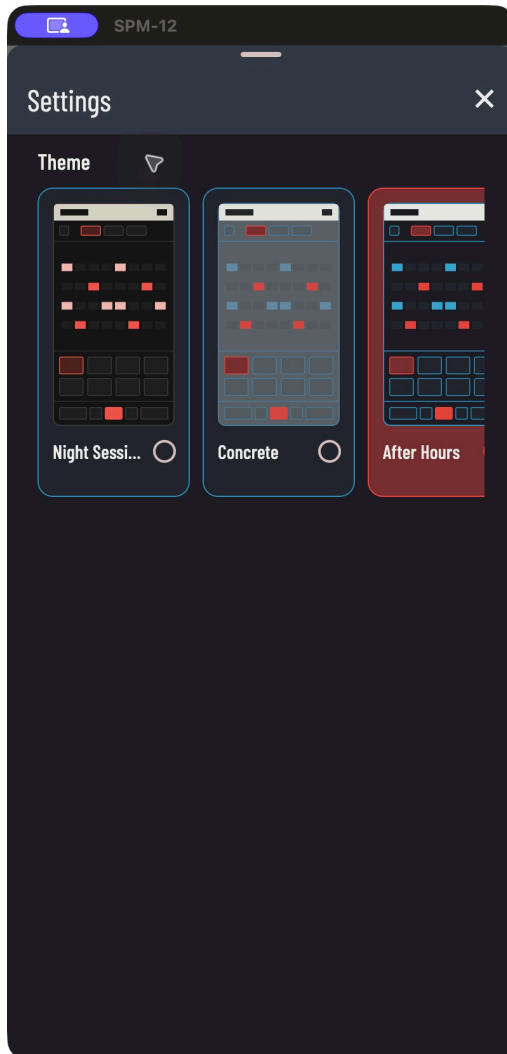
If a transfer times out:

1. Confirm both MIDI directions.
2. Confirm the selected input and output ports.
3. Remove MIDI routers, Bluetooth adapters or hubs from the test path.
4. Retry with a known SysEx-capable wired interface.
5. Restart the operation on both SPM-12 and the SP-12.

Some MIDI libraries wait forever for malformed or unterminated SysEx. SPM-12 uses a tolerant framing layer and a timeout so that the wizard can report the problem instead of hanging indefinitely.

10. Settings

Open the project menu and choose **Settings**.



The theme selector in Settings.

Choose the interface theme that best suits the room and display. The current themes include **Night Session**, **Concrete**, **After Hours**, **Gold Dust** and **Low Light**. The selection is stored for future sessions.

11. Troubleshooting

A project does not open

- Check that the extension is supported in What SPM-12 opens.
- For SPL-12 files, select both halves of the backup together.
- Try copying the file locally if it is stored in a cloud folder or removable location.
- If an HFE summary reports bad tracks, retain the original and avoid destructive edits.

A pad is silent

- Confirm that the pad contains a waveform.
- Check the pad level in Editing sounds.
- Check its output assignment and the corresponding channel in Master mixer and effects.
- Confirm the output is not muted and the master processing is enabled as intended.

A song skips material

- Confirm that every referenced segment exists.
- Inspect repeat boundaries and sub-song targets in Special steps.
- Check tempo changes if playback appears to stop or race unexpectedly.

Sampling input is unavailable

- Grant microphone/audio-input permission in the operating system.
- Reopen the sampler and select the correct device.
- Close another application that may have exclusive control of the input.

Save or export fails

- Confirm that the destination is writable and has free space.

- Use a new filename to protect the source.
- For damaged HFE images, review the unreadable-track warning in Save.
- For audio export, enable stems, stereo mix or both.

12. Safety, Support and Credits

Use the application at your own risk. Drum Machine Funk and Delta Seven Kft. cannot be held responsible for lost files, interrupted transfers or damage arising from unsupported interfaces, damaged media or modified hardware. Maintain independent backups of important disks and sampler memory.

When reporting a problem, include:

- application version and platform;
- document type and a non-sensitive example file when possible;
- exact steps that reproduce the problem;
- screenshots of the relevant view or error;
- MIDI interface model for SP-12 transfer issues.

SPM-12 is designed and developed by Drum Machine Funk in Budapest, Hungary. It is an independent creative tool and is not affiliated with E-mu Systems.

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